

To: Members of the Board of Education
From: Cindy Stevenson
Date: November 6, 2017
Topic: Class Size

The information in this memo comes from Visible Learning: A Synthesis of Over 800 Meta-Analyses Relating to Achievement by John Hattie. John Hattie is Professor of Education and Director of the Visible Learning Labs, University of Auckland, New Zealand. The book is the result of 15 years of research, and it synthesizes over 800 meta-analyses relating to the influences on achievement in school-aged students. The book represents the largest collection to date of evidence-based research into what actually works in schools to improve learning. In Jeffco the principals did a book study of this book and I did see the strategies that have been shown to have larger effect sizes take root in schools.

The following points summarize Hattie's writing on class size from pages 85-88.

- It is not difficult to find claims for both sides of the class size issue. One side of the argument is that reducing class size leads to more individualized instruction, higher quality instruction, greater scope for innovation and student-centered teaching, increased teacher morale, fewer disruptions, less misbehavior, and greater ease in engaging students in academics. On the other hand, literature does not support the claim that learning outcomes are enhanced when class size is reduced.
- It appears that reducing class size may have an effect on teacher and student work-related conditions which may or may not translate into an effect on achievement.
- The effect size of reducing class size on student achievement is relatively small. The effect size is remarkably consistent across multiple studies from multiple countries. The effect size is 0.10 to 0.20. In contrast, the effect size of effective feedback is about 0.75. The effect size should be weighed against the cost.
- The speculation from researchers is that smaller class sizes do not result in changes in teaching strategies. When teachers use the same strategies with larger or smaller class sizes, then achievement won't change. When teachers use high effect size strategies, achievement can change in average sized or smaller classes. This reality stresses the importance of strategies and practices that do change student achievement such as the giving of effective feedback.

- Hattie clearly states that simply reducing the number of students in front of teachers does not change teaching strategies or student achievement. However, he also states that increasing class size is poor policy. The critical variable is effective teaching, not class size.

Reducing class size may contribute to student, teacher, and parent satisfaction. There may be advantages related to attitudes and comfort. However, the research does not support class size as a variable that impacts student achievement.